Make Up and Fat is Not a Fairy Tale

By Nikki Giovanni and Jane Yolen

INTRODUCTION

We live in a very superficial society. It is very easy to fall into the trap of looking only at the surface of people, things, and ideas without taking the time and effort to delve deeper into them. This is where the adage "Don't Judge a Book By Its Cover" comes from. Literally, you cannot tell the quality of the contents of a book just by looking at the material used to hold it together. A book with a plain cover and simple title may be more important, more entertaining, or more useful than a book bound in a flashier manner.

This metaphor can be extended to many situations in life. Perhaps the best example is the relationships between people. Both Nikki Giovanni and Jane Yolen approach this metaphor from very different perspectives: Make-up and Obesity.

It is easy to fall in the trap of believing the most beautiful, shiny, or flashiest object is inherently "better." Only by maintaining strict self-discipline can we force ourselves to put these prejudices aside and look deeper into everything we do.

So, Ladies . . . . wash off your make-up and put on those comfy pants . . . . be your true self with Make Up by Nikki Giovanni and Fat is Not a Fairy Tale by Jane Yolen.

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Make Up

we make up our faces

for lots of reasons

to go to the movies

or some junior prom

to see ice hockey

or watch the Dodgers come home again

defeated

going to the grocery store

only requires lipstick

while a bridge game

can mean a quick trip

to the hairdresser for a touch up

i clean my makeup

before going to bed

alone

and if my mood is foul

i spray the sheets

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with Ultra Ban

most faces are made up
before the public is faced
whether male female or child
it's always so appropriate
doncha know
to put a little mascara
around the eyes

we make up fantasies to face life
we need to believe
we are good on the job
or at least in the bed

we make up lies
to impress people
who are making up lies
to impress us
and if either took all
the make up off

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life would not be
worth living

we make up excuses
to say i'm sorry –that-
forgive me –because-
and after all didn't i tell you
-why-

and i make up with you
because you aren't strong
enough to reach out
to say
come home i need you

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Nikki Giovanni
Book: The Selected Poems of Nikki Giovanni 1968-1995
ISBN: 978-0688140472
Publisher: William Morrow
Date (Month/Year): Jan 1996

Fat is Not a Fairy Tale

I am thinking of a fairy tale,
Cinder Elephant,
Sleeping Tubby,
Snow Weight,
where the princess is not
anorexic, wasp-waisted,
flinging herself down the stairs.

I am thinking of a fairy tale,
Hansel and Great,
Repoundsel,
Bounty and the Beast,
where the beauty
has a pillowed breast,
and fingers plump as sausage.

I am thinking of a fairy tale
that is not yet written,
for a teller not yet born,

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for a listener not yet conceived,
for a world not yet won,
where everything round is good:
the sun, wheels, cookies, and the princess.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jane Yolen
Book: Once Upon a Time (She Said)
ISBN: 978-1886778610
Publisher: NESFA Press
Date (Month/Year): Aug 2005

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